From Kyneton [redacted] Branch

Observations from [redacted] volunteers who staffed local booths and pre-poll booths in the Bendigo electorate for the 2025 Federal election and consequent suggestions.

a) Many of those handing out HTVs for the [redacted] and The [redacted] were allowed to hand out closer than the mandated requirement that they be 6m from the booth entrance.

This happened at most of the local booths in our area but the local AEC staff on election day did not enforce the requirement.

b) Bunting and A Frames were placed closer that 6m to the entry and in some cases on the polling booth structure itself.

At one booth our volunteers complained to the Returning Officer about this prior to the start of voting. The Returning Officer was not sure of the rules and said they would check – Eventually they required the [redacted] offending signs and bunting to be taken down.

c) Too many people handing out for the one candidate

The [redacted] had far more that the necessary number of people handing out for their candidate at many booths some of whom were quite aggressive.

This was especially applicable to what appeared to be Plymouth Brethren workers handing out for the [redacted] candidate

On one pre-poll booth they had 15 at the one time and on election day that had 7 at our bigger booth often inside the 6m limit, confusing voters and edging out everyone else.

d) Smothering almost all booth with bunting and A Frames

In our electorate of Bendigo and in many other electorates the [redacted] came to the booths on the evening/night before election day and smothered the booths with bunting and signage leaving next to no room for other parties' signage. Many voters were offended by the overkill.

e) Apparent lack of training of AEC booth staff and Returning Officers

The lack of enforcement of the 6m rule for handing out HTVs and for Party signage is just one example of the apparent lack of training and knowledge of the rules of local AEC returning officers.At one local booth counting did not start for half an hour after the booth close whilst the Returning Officer read the rules on how to conduct the count.

Branch suggestions for amendments or changes to AEC Rules and Practices

(i) Restrict Party signage and A Frames at Polling Booths and Pre-polling Booths:

That rules similar to those in Victorian State elections be introduced to significantly limit Party signage at Federal Pre-poll centres and election day polling booths.

(ii) That temporary AEC staff receive increased and adequate pre-election day training.

(iii) That the 6m rule for distributions of htvs and for signage be enforced by AEC officials at polling and pre-polling booths.

(iv) That consideration be given to limiting the number of people handing out HTVs for the one Party at a booth.

(v) Non-voting groups such as the Plymouth Brethren and "stranger" groups involvement should somehow be regulated

Local Government management of Party signage

The [redacted] candidate appeared to be permitted to display large promotional signage prior to the election for a period well in excess of the time allowed under their local law particularly in the Bendigo CBD yet the Council did not appear to police their own local laws. Councils varied in their responsiveness in addressing illegal signs.

Branch proposal:

That Councils be required to enforce their own and State and Federal laws and promptly have taken down election signs that contravene those laws.